

PROPOSAL • WEBSITE, CONTENT & SEARCH • SEPTEMBER 2026

Put the work on the **record.**

A new pedersenhoupt.com: designed, built, photographed and written in ten weeks, with the firm's own work as the content.

PREPARED FOR

Pedersen & Houpt, P.C.

PREPARED BY

Upperhand, Chicago

FIXED FEE

\$50,000

LAUNCH

Week 10



THE SHORT VERSION

10 weeks

From kickoff to launch

7 templates

Designed phone-first, with you

26 portraits

Every attorney, on site at 161 North Clark

6 articles

Live on launch day

\$0 retainer

Hosting at cost after launch

What we are proposing

To the partners of Pedersen & Houpt,

In the last few years the firm represented JRTC Holdings in buying the Thompson Center, advised Skolnik Industries on its sale to Pelican Energy Partners, and received its first Chambers recognition. The website mentions each of these once, if at all.

You asked us what the website is for. Our answer is in section two: it should be the firm's first meeting with a client, a way to be found, and a reason to come back. The rest of this document is how we would get it there, with launch a full year ahead of the firm's seventieth anniversary in October 2027.

It is one fixed-fee project, itemized below: a new site, photography at 161 North Clark, the copy and search work behind it, and six articles written from work the firm has already made public. Ten weeks from kickoff to launch. We would build it with you, starting from the partners' own answers about how clients find and choose the firm. Every figure about the current site comes from our audit of it in September.

John Williamson

CO-FOUNDER, UPPERHAND

Greg McDonald

CO-FOUNDER, UPPERHAND

What the website is for

By the partners' own account, the site brings in almost no client contact today. It should do three jobs.

01

The first meeting

A referral or a lateral candidate will often look at the site before calling. The homepage should put the firm's people and matters first, with no stock photography and the client login where clients expect it.

02

Being found

Today the firm is hard to find in search for anything but its own name. Every practice page should answer the questions clients type, and every closed matter should become a page that can rank.

03

A reason to come back

About five posts a year is too few for a firm this active. Regular articles with bylines and faces, six of them on launch day, and a year of them in place before the anniversary.

What success looks like

MEASURE	TODAY	AT LAUNCH
Phone load time LARGEST ELEMENT ON SCREEN. GOOGLE'S BENCHMARK IS 2.5 S	2.8 to 7.8 s	→ under 2 s
Pages with a written description	2 of 169	→ Every page
Homepage weight	2.4 MB	→ under 1 MB
Google Business Profile	2.8 stars, 4 reviews, appears unclaimed	→ Claimed, verified, photographed

MEASURE

TODAY

AT LAUNCH

Attorney portraits

~~4 backdrops across 6 partners~~

→ One light, every attorney

New publications since April 2022

0

→ 6 live at launch

Directory listings

~~FindLaw and Lexology show Suite 3100~~

→ Every listing at Suite 2700

Accessibility

~~Contrast failures on desktop~~

→ WCAG 2.2 AA, every template

FOR THE FIRST YEAR

At launch we set up tracking for form inquiries, newsletter sign-ups and twenty practice searches agreed in discovery, so the first year is measured against a starting point.

TODAY

WRITTEN BY GOOGLE, FROM THE HOMEPAGE

pedersenhaupt.com › professionals

Brian Collins: Pedersen & Houpt

Cookie settings · Client Focus · Services · Professionals · News & Alerts ...

Pedersen & Houpt Law Offices

2.8 ★★★★★ 4 reviews

[Own this business?](#)

APPEARS UNCLAIMED

AT LAUNCH

WRITTEN BY THE FIRM

pedersenhaupt.com › people › brian-collins

Brian P. Collins, Managing Partner | Pedersen & Houpt

Managing Partner of Pedersen & Houpt. Advises Chicago companies and their owners on M&A, private equity and finance.

Pedersen & Houpt

Law firm · 161 N Clark St, Suite 2700

[Claimed](#) · [photos](#) · [hours](#) · [website](#)

CLAIMED BY THE FIRM

What a client sees when they search a partner's name. The description on the right is a sample; the real ones are written with each attorney.

Scope of work

01

Website design

A design system and seven templates, designed phone-first and people-first: faces on the homepage, no stock photography, and the firm's own logo and red. What it looks like comes out of discovery, from the partners' answers about the firm, its clients and its people. It comes with a clickable prototype, two rounds of revisions and a brand playbook so later edits stay consistent.

02

Website development

A fast, secure site on Next.js and Vercel, with a headless CMS your team can edit without calling anyone. We would recommend Sanity and confirm it in discovery. Every page, bio and archived publication moves over, every old address redirects, and LawPay, client login, the newsletter and forms carry across. We handle the move from Firmseek, including the domain, so the switch happens without downtime.

03

Optimization

Pages that load in under 2 seconds on a phone and meet WCAG 2.2 AA, with cookie consent built into the design rather than added at the end. Each page gets a written description and structured data. We set up Google Analytics 4, keeping your history, and Search Console, and correct the Google Business Profile and directory listings.

Content

Photography on site at 161 North Clark, and the content you already have, moved over and improved: every existing page sorted and updated, new titles and descriptions, tags by practice, clean addresses with redirects so search traction carries over, and one house style throughout. Plus every practice page rewritten around what clients search for, an edit of every bio, six new articles and a keyword map for each practice.

Designed with you

The design comes from working with you. In discovery we ask the partners dedicated questions about the firm, its clients and its people, and the site is built from their answers.

We have already sketched a few starting points from our September audit. We'll bring them to the kickoff as conversation starters.

01

How do clients find the firm today, and what makes them choose it?

02

What should each practice be known for?

03

Which matters best show the work?

04

What should a lateral candidate see first?

05

What sets the firm's people apart?

06

What should the site say when the firm turns seventy?

Work the site leaves out

What we found in September, and where each piece would go on the new site. Everything here is already public.

CORPORATE • ANNOUNCED JANUARY 2025

Skolnik Industries, acquired by Pelican Energy Partners

Counsel to the seller, a steel-drum maker

TODAY

The buyer's press release on PR Newswire. Not in your newsroom.

NEW SITE

A matter page

REAL ESTATE • 2022 TO 2025

The James R. Thompson Center

Counsel to JRTC Holdings on the acquisition and the build-to-suit

TODAY

One news item, dated November 2025. The state signed the sale agreement in March 2022.

NEW SITE

A matter page with the full timeline

RECOGNITION • 2026

Chambers Spotlight USA, Real Estate

The firm's first Chambers recognition

TODAY

One post in August.

NEW SITE

The Real Estate page and the bios of the lawyers Chambers lists

SPEAKING • JANUARY 2026

Larry Byrne's IICLE webcast

A continuing legal education program

TODAY

One alert.

NEW SITE

Article 05, written up for the clients who missed it

RESULTS • UNDATED

A \$218M office-to-hotel financing. The Morton Grove handgun-ordinance case.

Two matters the site already lists

TODAY

Undated lines on one page.

NEW SITE

Matter cards on the practice and attorney pages

PUBLICATIONS • 2001 TO 2022

Twenty-nine articles

Written by the firm's own lawyers

TODAY

An archive. Nothing new since April 2022, and alerts fell from 22 in 2020 to one to three a year.

NEW SITE

Moved over, dated and tagged by practice

For comparison: Levenfeld Pearlstein, Much Shelist, Golan Christie Taglia and Neal Gerber Eisenberg each published new insights in the four weeks before our audit.

Articles, old and new

The site already carries 80 newsroom items: 46 publications, 24 alerts and 10 news posts. None of them starts over. Each moves to the new site, and every one that still earns search traffic keeps its standing through a redirect from its old address.

On top of that, six new articles go live on launch day. Each starts with a thirty-minute interview with the partner who did the work, and nothing publishes without that partner's sign-off. We write only from what the firm has already made public, and we settle the final six topics with you in discovery.

1 Interview

2 Draft

3 Partner sign-off

4 Published, with a LinkedIn version

SIX NEW ARTICLES FOR LAUNCH, AS A FIRST PROPOSAL

01 REAL ESTATE

Buying from the State: what a public seller asks of the buyer

From the Thompson Center acquisition

02 CORPORATE

Selling a manufacturing business: what the buyer asks for first

From the Skolnik Industries sale

03 REAL ESTATE & FINANCING

Office to hotel: how a downtown conversion gets financed

From the \$218M redevelopment financing

04 LITIGATION

Before you need it: protecting trade secrets inside a Chicago company

From the iCONN v. Conxall trade-secret trial

05 SEMINAR

The January IICLE program, written up

From Larry Byrne's webcast

06 THE FIRM

Sixty-nine years of Pedersen & Houpt

From Peer Pedersen's founding in 1957 to 161 North Clark, a year before the seventieth

Photography at 161 North Clark



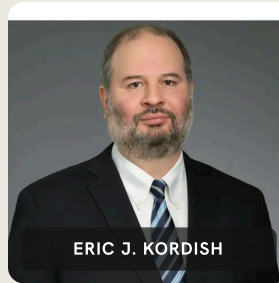
BRIAN P. COLLINS



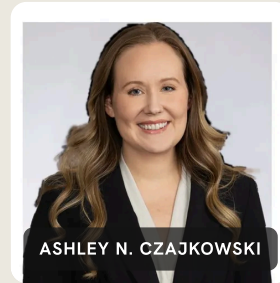
JOHN H. MUEHLSTEIN



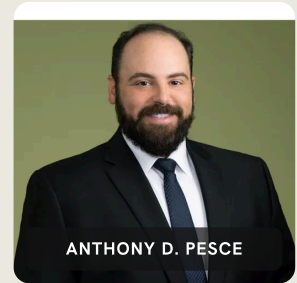
MICHAEL P. SULLIVAN



ERIC J. KORDISH



ASHLEY N. CZAJKOWSKI



ANTHONY D. PESCE

Six partners from your site today, on four different backdrops.

THE SHOT LIST

Portraits. Every attorney, one lighting setup, in color, full frame and cut-out.

The office. Glass walls and working rooms, in use.

The building and the street. 161 North Clark, the Loop and the river. No stock photography.

Search

- ✓ **A written description on every page.** Two of the 169 pages we crawled have one, so Google writes its own. On attorney pages it has been pulling homepage text such as "cookie settings, client focus."

Six partners on the site today, on four different backdrops. One full day or two half-days on site gives every attorney the same light and crop, and gives the firm photographs of its own office and street to use everywhere.

ON THE DAY

A two-person crew, for one full day or two half-days.

Getting every attorney in front of the camera is the hard part of the calendar, so ten-minute slots go out two weeks ahead.

Office and street shots fill the gaps, and selects follow within five business days.

- ✓ **Structured data** for the firm, each attorney and each practice, so search engines can read the site the way a client would.

Keeping what already ranks

A new site should not start from zero. Before anything moves, we pull a year of search data for every page in the sitemap and sort each one. Pages that earn visits or links keep their standing: the old address redirects to the new one, page for page, so the traction carries over. Their titles and descriptions get rewritten for how clients actually search, and their copy gets updated where the law or the facts have changed.

46
PUBLICATIONS

34
PRACTICE PAGES

27
BIOS

24
ALERTS

16
OTHER

10
NEWS

All 157 pages in the current sitemap. Every one gets a decision.

Keep

Moves over with a new title and description. Bios and news, for example.

Update

Copy refreshed, dated, bylined and tagged by practice. Publications whose law has moved on.

Merge

Overlapping pages combined into one, every old address pointing at it. The 34 practice pages become seven.

Retire

No traffic and no future, redirected to the closest live page, never a dead link. Likely some 2020 alerts, if the data agrees.

OLD TAGS

pedersenhoupt.com/services-Corporate-Business-Counseling.html

Corporate and Business Counseling: Pedersen & Houpt

No description written. Google picks text from the page.

NEW TAGS

pedersenhoupt.com/practices/corporate

Corporate & M&A Lawyers in Chicago | Pedersen & Houpt

Counsel to Chicago companies and their owners on buying, selling and financing a business, from the letter of intent to after the close.

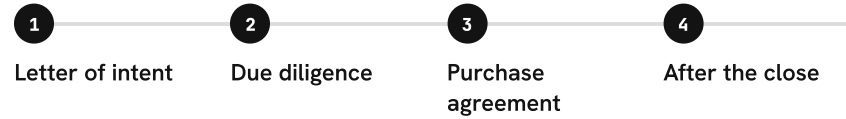
One practice page, its tags today and a sample of the new ones. The old address redirects to the new one.

Practice pages that answer the question

A business owner selling a company searches for what happens next, not for "corporate and business counseling." Each practice page gets rewritten around those questions, with the lawyers who handle them beside the answer.

EXAMPLE PAGE

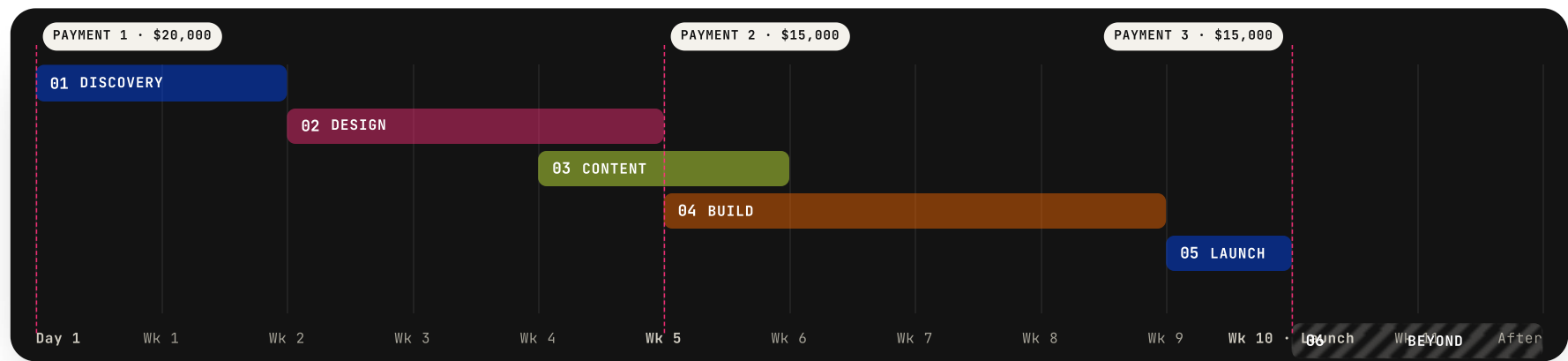
Selling your business



With Brian Collins and Eric Kordish, and the matters they closed

Ten weeks, day one to launch

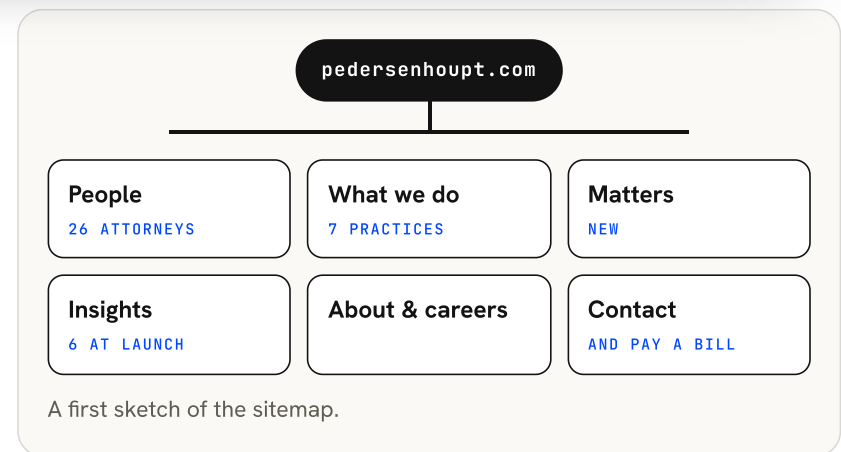
Five phases that overlap on purpose. Content overlaps the end of design and the start of the build.



Discovery & planning

DAY 1 TO WEEK 2

A two-hour kickoff at 161 North Clark and thirty-minute interviews with the Managing Partner and a partner from each practice group. We ask dedicated questions: how clients find and choose the firm, what each practice wants to be known for, and which matters best show the work. We also read every page, the analytics and the directory listings. The phase ends with the sitemap, redirect map, shoot dates and success measures in writing.



WE NEED FROM YOU

- One point person
- Access to analytics, the domain and the current site's admin
- Thirty minutes from a partner in each group

PAYMENT 1

At signing, day 1 **\$20,000**

02

Design

WEEKS 2 TO 5

The design comes from the partners' answers in discovery. It becomes a design system and seven templates, phone and desktop, in a clickable prototype, with a brand playbook. Each of the two revision rounds takes one consolidated set of comments from the firm.

WE NEED FROM YOU

- One set of comments per round, within three business days
- A yes on the design by the end of week 5

PAYMENT 2

Milestone 1: design approved, end of week 5 **\$15,000**



The seven templates, each designed for the phone first. What they look like comes out of discovery.

03

Content & photography

WEEKS 4 TO 6

Two weeks of production: the photography, practice pages rewritten around client questions, the existing articles sorted, updated and

retagged, the main page copy, bio edits, the six new articles and a description for every page.

WE NEED FROM YOU

- Each attorney at the shoot for their ten minutes
- Thirty minutes from each article's partner
- Sign-off on copy within a week

84 Development

WEEKS 5 TO 9

We build each template as it is approved, then move the content over and redirect every old address. A private staging link and a short progress note arrive every Friday.

WE NEED FROM YOU

- Final copy approvals
- Access to LawPay and the client login provider

OLD ADDRESS

NEW ADDRESS

~~/professionals-Brian-Collins.html~~



/people/brian-collins

~~/services-Corporate-Business-Counseling.html~~



/practices/corporate

~~/newsroom-news-110.html~~



/matters/thompson-center

~~/focus-results.html~~



/matters

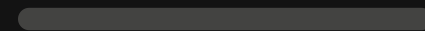
A sample of the redirect map. Every old address gets a new one, so links from directories, articles and email signatures keep working.

Optimize, test & launch

WEEKS 9 TO 10

Testing on every device and of every redirect, an hour of CMS training with a written guide, then launch on a weekday morning and two weeks of monitoring.

TODAY, SLOWER
RUN



7.8 s

TODAY, FASTER
RUN



2.8 s

AT LAUNCH



< 2 s

Largest element on screen, on a phone, measured with Lighthouse.

WE NEED FROM YOU

- An hour for training
- A launch date the partners agree on

PAYMENT 3

Milestone 2: launch, week 10 \$15,000

06

Beyond launch

AFTER WEEK 10 • OPTIONAL

Launch leaves a full year before the firm turns seventy in October 2027, and that year is for publishing: each article is another way in from search, and the anniversary arrives on a site that has been kept current. Nothing after launch is on a retainer.

UPKEEP

- Hosting passed through at cost, about \$15 a month
- A prepaid block of hours for updates and security patches
- Another block only when you need one

CONTENT

- Articles ordered as you want them
- Weekly or monthly, with bylines and faces
- From client questions and newly closed matters

Fee and payment terms

\$50,000, fixed.

The fee covers the seven line items here, from kickoff to two weeks after launch. It is not an estimate and it does not grow with hours. If we've underestimated the work, that is ours to absorb. The largest line is development, which covers the build, the migration and the redirects. The firm owns the site, its code and its content, and has full rights to the photographs.

PAYMENT TERMS

Three payments: 40 percent at signing, 30 percent when you approve the design at the end of week 5, and 30 percent at launch. Invoices are due in fifteen days.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE IT

Work not listed here, such as a client portal, a second office or a practice group added mid-build. We would quote it as a fixed fee before starting.

This proposal holds through October 31, 2026.

PAYMENT 1 • 40%

DAY 1

\$20,000

At signing

PAYMENT 2 • 30%

WEEK 5

\$15,000

Milestone 1: design approved

PAYMENT 3 • 30%

WEEK 10

\$15,000

Milestone 2: launch

LINE ITEM

FIXED

01	Discovery & planning	\$4,000
	+ Kickoff at 161 North Clark and interviews with the Managing Partner and a partner from each practice group + An audit of every page in your sitemap, your analytics and your directory listings + Sitemap, content model, redirect map and shoot plan, signed off before design starts	
02	Design	\$11,000
	+ A design system shaped by what we learn in discovery: type, color, grid and components + Seven templates: home, practice, attorney, matter, article, about and careers, contact + A brand playbook, so later edits stay consistent + Designed phone-first, with a prototype you can click and two rounds of revisions	
03	Development	\$15,500
	+ The build, on a CMS your team can edit + Every bio, practice, news item and archived publication moved over + A redirect for every old address, plus LawPay, client login, newsletter and forms	
04	Photography	\$7,500
	+ One full day or two half-days at 161 North Clark, with a two-person crew + Every attorney on one light and one crop, plus the office, the building and the Loop + About 150 retouched selects, sized for web, print and LinkedIn, with usage rights for the firm	
05	Copy & SEO	\$6,500
	+ Every practice page rewritten to answer what clients search for, plus the home, about and careers pages and an edit of every bio + A written title and description for every page, and schema for the firm, each attorney and each practice + Google Business Profile claimed and filled out, directory listings corrected, a keyword map per practice + Every existing page sorted into keep, update, merge or retire, with its old address redirected so search traction carries over	
06	Six launch articles	\$3,000
	+ Written from work the firm has already made public + Each one starts with a thirty-minute interview with the partner who did the work + Nothing publishes without that partner's sign-off	
07	Optimization, QA & launch	\$2,500
	+ Under 2 seconds on a phone, cookie consent and ADA accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA) built in + Testing on every device and of every redirect + An hour of CMS training, a written guide, and two weeks of monitoring after launch	

TOTAL, FIXED FEE

\$50,000

After launch

None of this is in the \$50,000 and none of it is required. Nothing is on a monthly retainer: hosting passes through at cost, and everything else you buy when you need it.

ESTIMATE THE FIRST YEAR AFTER LAUNCH

Articles a month 0

Blocks of hours in the year 2

FIRST YEAR AFTER LAUNCH

\$3,180

Hosting \$180 · hours \$3,000 · articles \$0

Hosting

Passed through at cost, about \$15 a month, with no markup.

\$15

A MONTH, AT COST

Block of hours

Ten hours for updates, security patches, new pages and small changes, prepaid and used as needed. When it runs out, you decide whether to buy another.

\$1,500

PER 10-HOUR BLOCK

Articles

Each from a thirty-minute partner interview, with a search brief and a LinkedIn version. Order them as you want them.

\$600

PER ARTICLE

New-hire portraits

A half-day session in the launch lighting, so new attorneys match the rest of the firm.

\$900

PER SESSION

Search and feature projects

A push on one practice in search, a client portal, a recruiting section. Scoped and quoted one at a time, before we start.

Quoted

ONE AT A TIME

About Upperhand

Upperhand is a studio in Chicago, led by John Williamson and Greg McDonald. We've spent decades starting, running and selling companies, and building the brands and products inside them.

Both of us work on this project with you from kickoff to launch, supported internally by our dedicated team. We've hired agencies ourselves, which is why this proposal has a fixed fee and an end date.

We will be at 161 North Clark for the kickoff and the photography.

What happens next

01

Walk through it

A call with both of us next week to go through the scope and answer questions before anything is signed.

02

Sign

A short services agreement by e-signature, with this scope attached as written.

03

Kick off

After the first payment, a kickoff at 161 North Clark within five business days.

04

Launch

Ten weeks later, the new pedersenhaupt.com goes live.

John Williamson

john@getupperhand.io

Greg McDonald

greg@getupperhand.io

 **Upperhand®**

Prepared for Pedersen & Houpt, P.C., September 24, 2026. Confidential. Figures about the current site are from our audit of pedersenhaupt.com in September 2026.

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